PTO System – Administrator SOP

1. Purpose

This SOP (Standard Operating Procedure) explains how to operate and maintain the PTO system: approving requests, the weekly check, adding and removing employees, automatic policy grants, fixing mistakes, and recovering from errors without breaking the connection between the form, the flows and the tracker.

2. Scope

- The PTO tracker workbook (RAH_PTO_Tracker.xlsx) the official PTO record for full-time office staff.
- The Microsoft Form "Time Off Request".
- Power Automate flow 1 "PTO Request – Approval" and flow 2 "PTO - Automatic policy grants".
- Out of scope: paying PTO in Paycor (payroll uses the days in the tracker) and the employee steps (see RAH-SOP-PTO-001).

3. System overview

3.1 Components

Component	What it does	Where
Time Off Request form (Microsoft Forms)	Employees submit requests.	Microsoft Forms
Flow 1 - PTO Request Approval	Runs on every form response. Adds the request to Requests, sends the approval with the balance, writes approved time off to the Log, emails the employee. If the balance is not enough, it warns the employee and, when days are unpaid, notifies Allison (payroll).	Power Automate
Flow 2 - PTO Automatic policy grants	Runs every day at 6:00 AM Central. Adds every grant that is due and not logged to the Log, up to the 20-day maximum balance, and emails the employee (CC Management).	Power Automate
RAH_PTO_Tracker.xlsx	The official record. Calculates balances, grants, alerts and statements.	OneDrive

Component	What it does	Where
Approvals	Where the approver decides.	Outlook email or the Approvals app in Teams

3.2 How a request flows

1. Employee submits the form.
2. Flow 1 looks up the employee (tblEmployees) and the request type (tblTypeMap), and adds a row to Requests with Status = Pending.
3. If the request is for more PTO than the available balance, the employee is emailed right away with the days that will be paid and unpaid, and the approval shows a warning.
4. Flow 1 sends the approval to the Approver with the available balance and the balance after the request.
5. Approve: Requests → Approved, the paid days are added to the Log, and the employee gets an email with the balance left. Days not covered by the balance are logged as Unpaid day, and Allison (payroll) gets an email with the details.
6. Approve - borrow from next grant: all days are paid. The days not covered by the balance are logged as Advance (borrowed); the balance goes negative until the next grant. No payroll email.
7. Denied: Requests → Denied, and the employee gets an email with the comments.

3.3 How automatic grants work

1. The Grant Calendar lists every grant each employee should receive under the policy (up to 50 employees).
2. When a grant date arrives and no matching Grant row exists in the Log (within ±15 days), its Status shows "DUE - not logged".
3. Every morning, flow 2 reads those rows, adds a Grant row to the Log (Entered by = Power Automate (auto grant)) and emails the employee. The grant only adds days up to the 20-day maximum (Max balance in flow 2); nobody loses days. If the balance is already 20 or more, the grant is logged with 0 days and a "capped at 20-day maximum" note.
4. The Grant Calendar then shows "Logged", so the grant is never added twice.

> **Self-healing:** if flow 2 is off or fails for some days, nothing is lost. The next successful run adds every grant that is still "DUE - not logged", including late ones.

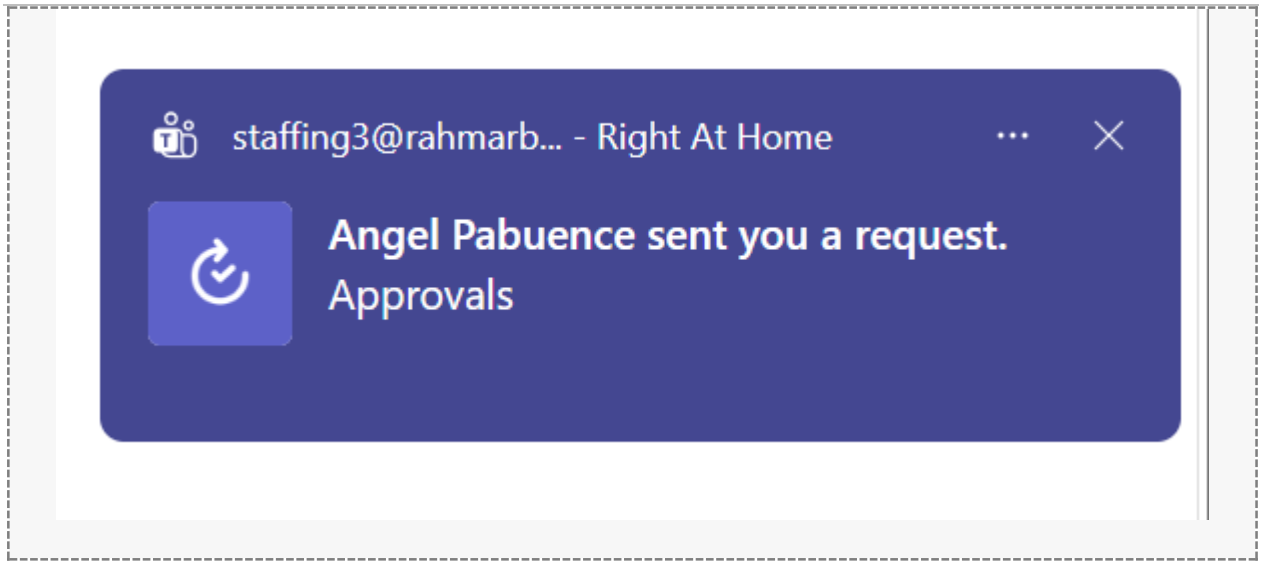


Figure 1. Flow 1 "PTO Request - Request" in Teams

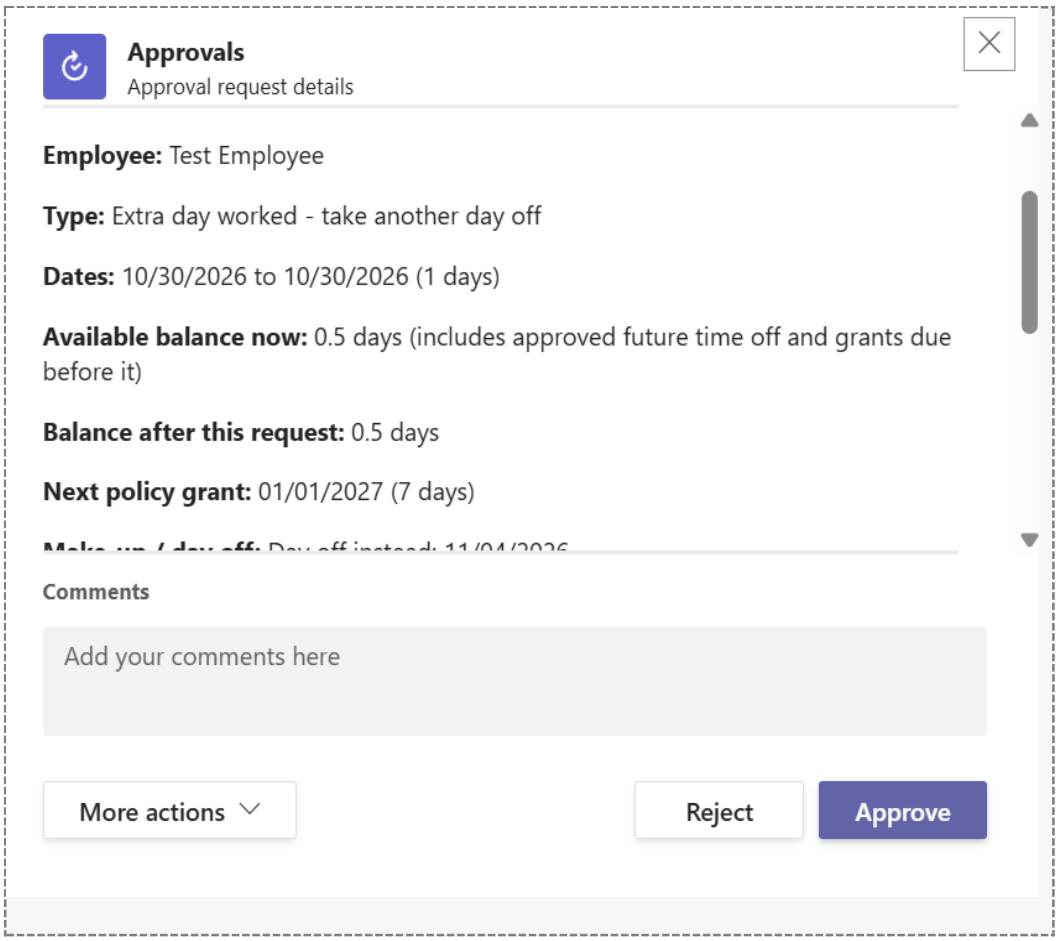


Figure 2. Detailed request sent by the user.

3.4 Workbook tabs

Tab	Purpose	Excel table used by the flows
How It Works	Quick guide inside the file.	–
Employees	Roster, balances, next grant, alerts and counters.	tblEmployees
Log	Every PTO event. The only place where balances change.	tblLog
Requests	Every form request and its decision.	tblRequests
Statement	Printable history for one employee.	–
Settings	Policy tiers, entry types, report date, form-to-log mapping.	tblTypeMap
Corrections	Audit trail of fixes made when the old PTO sheets were migrated.	–
Grant Calendar	Every policy grant and its status.	tblGrants

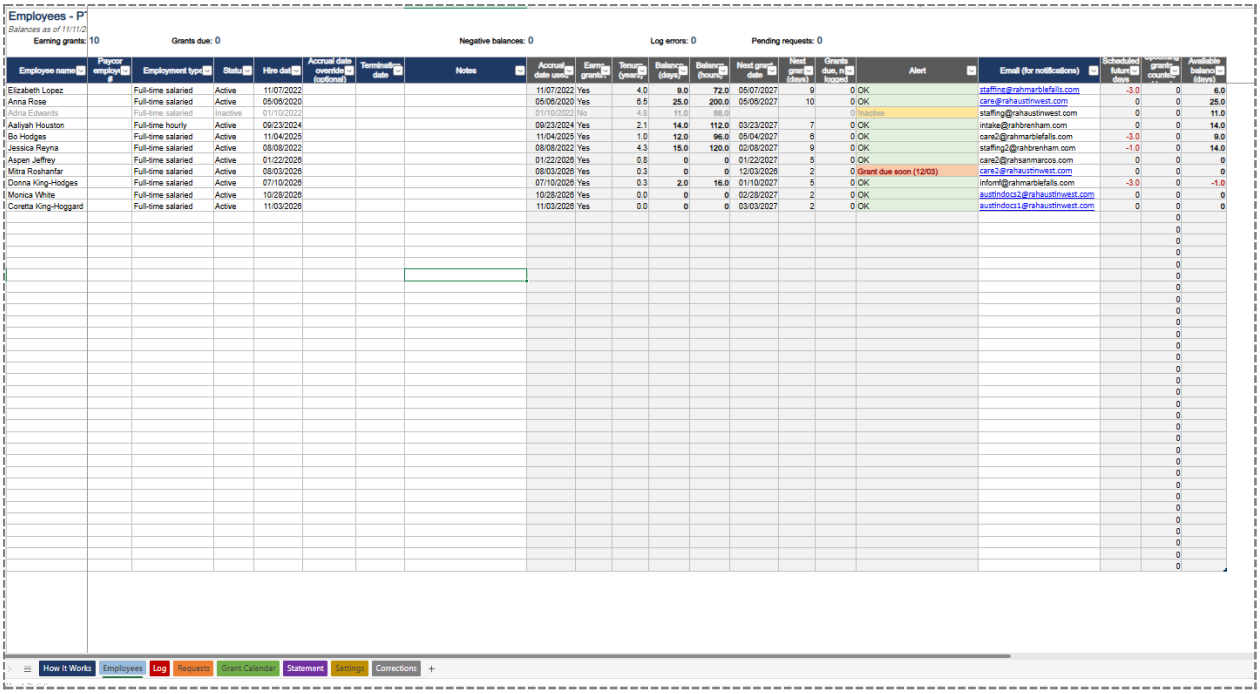


Figure 3. Tracker - Employees tab with counters and the Alert column

4. Golden rules (what never to do)

The flows find tables by name **and by their position in the file**. Breaking any of these rules can disconnect the flows.

Never…	Why
Add, delete, rename or move tabs that contain a table.	Changes the table order. Flow actions then point to the wrong table ("Id column not found").
Rename tables or column headers.	The flows look them up by name.
Hide columns on the Grant Calendar (or any table). Make them narrow instead.	Flow 2 fails: "Unable to match columns in the filtered view".
Delete, move or rename the file, or upload a copy with another name.	The flows lose the file ID ("itemNotFound"). To replace it, overwrite it with the same name (OneDrive sync folder or Upload → Replace).
Edit or delete an approved Log row to change a balance.	Breaks the audit trail. Use Adjustment (+) / (-) (section 8).
Type in grey columns.	They are formulas.
Insert rows inside a table.	Type in the next empty row; the table extends by itself.
Rename an employee who already has Log rows.	History is linked by name.
Leave Settings → Report date override filled in.	Balances and due grants use that date instead of today.

5. Routine procedures

5.1 Approving a request (Approver)

1. Open the approval email in Outlook (or the Approvals app).
2. Review the employee, dates, days, available balance and balance after the request.
3. Choose **Approve**, **Approve - borrow from next grant** or **Reject**. Always add a comment when rejecting (for example, "Wrong dates, please resubmit" or "Duplicate").
4. Click **Submit**. The tracker and the employee email update automatically.

Note: approvals expire after 30 days. When the balance is not enough, the approval shows a warning. Approve = the extra days are unpaid and Allison is notified automatically. Approve - borrow from next grant = all days are paid as an advance and the balance goes negative until the next grant. If the approval email does not arrive, approve from Teams → Approvals or Power Automate → Action items → Approvals.

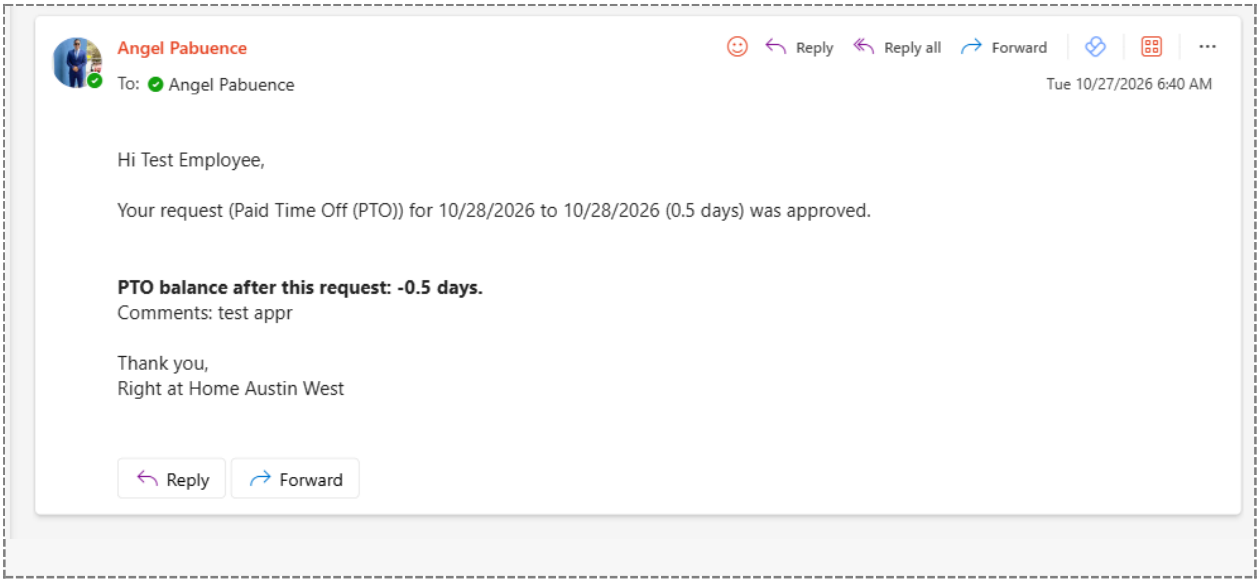


Figure 4. Approval request in Outlook – Approve / Reject with comments

5.2 Weekly check (PTO Administrator, about 5 minutes)

1. **Employees tab counters:** Grants due = 0 and Log errors = 0. Pending requests only for recent requests.
2. **Alert column:** review anything other than OK (Negative balance, Grant due, Enter hire date…).
3. **Log → Check column:** filter for anything that is not OK and fix it.
4. **Power Automate → each flow → Run history:** no failed (red) runs. Open any failed run and see section 9.
5. Make sure **Settings → Report date override** is empty.

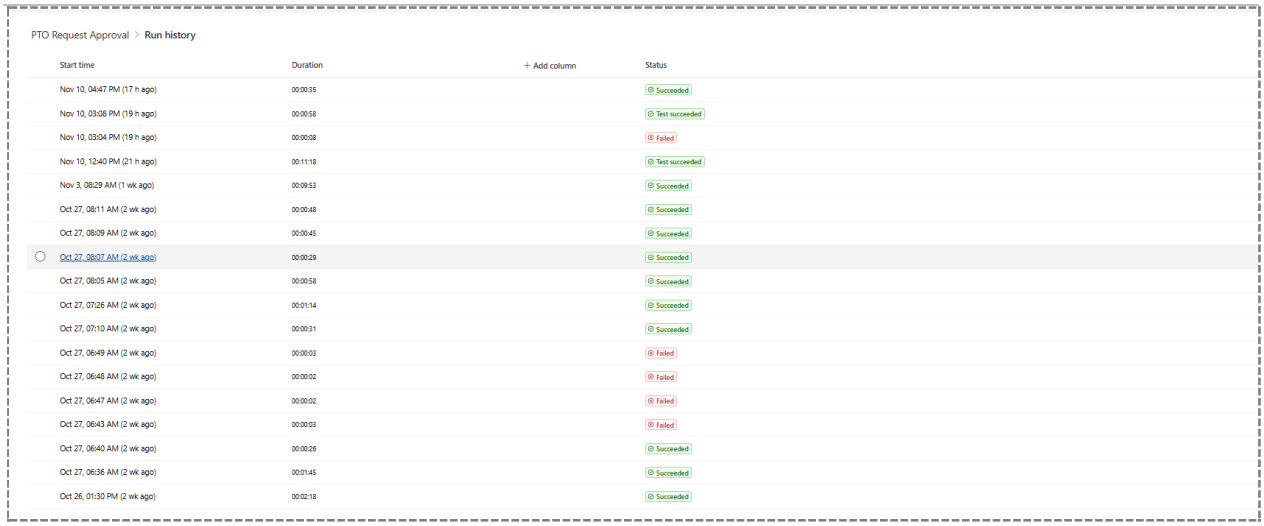


Figure 5. Power Automate run history (28-day view)

5.3 Recording an entry that did not come through the form

Examples: a weekend banked day agreed by email, a company holiday, an advance approved by the Approver.

1. Go to the Log tab and click the first empty row under the table.
2. Fill in the white columns: **Date**, **Employee** (drop-down), **Type** (drop-down), **Days** (always positive; whole days only), **Notes** (what and who approved), **Entered by** (your name).
3. Several consecutive days: one row with the total days, dated on the first day, with the range in Notes.
4. Check that the Check column shows OK.

Type	Effect	Use it for
Grant	+	Policy grant (normally added by flow 2).
Banked day	+	Approved extra day worked, added to the balance.
Adjustment (+)	+	Correction that adds days. Explain in Notes.
PTO used	–	Paid day off from the balance.
Advance (borrowed)	–	PTO used before it is earned, approved by the Approver.
Adjustment (-)	–	Correction that removes days. Explain in Notes.
Payout	–	Not used: unused PTO is not paid out.

Type	Effect	Use it for
Unpaid day, Bereavement, Holiday, Jury duty, Day swap	0	Recorded for reference. No balance change.

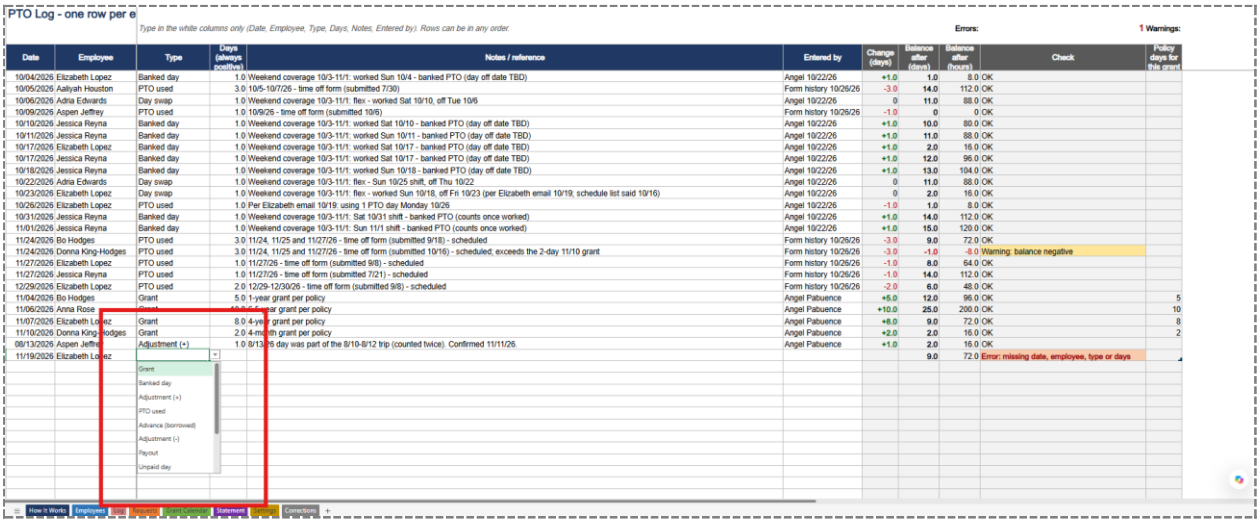


Figure 6. Log tab – example of a manual row and the Check column

6. Roster changes

6.1 New full-time employee

1. **Employees tab:** in the first empty row type the Employee name, Employment type, Status = Active, Hire date and Email (for notifications).
2. Confirm that Next grant date and Next grant (days) fill in, and that the employee appears on the Grant Calendar.
3. **Form:** open the form → question "Your name" → add the name **exactly** as on the Employees tab (same spelling, spaces and hyphens).
4. If the employee already had PTO before joining the tracker, add it to the Log (Grant or Adjustment rows with a note).

> **Important:** if the name in the form does not match the Employees tab exactly, flow 1 fails at "Get employee".

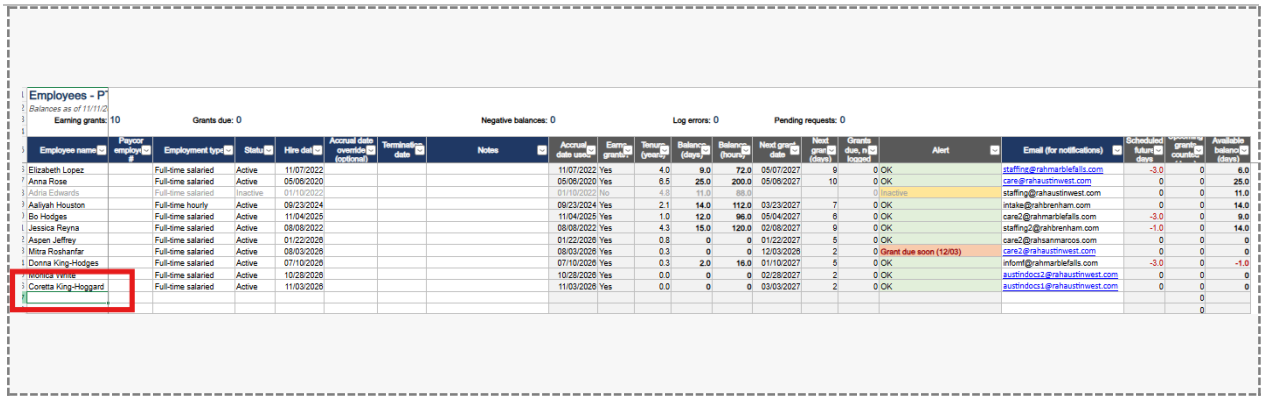


Figure 7. Employees tab – new employee row

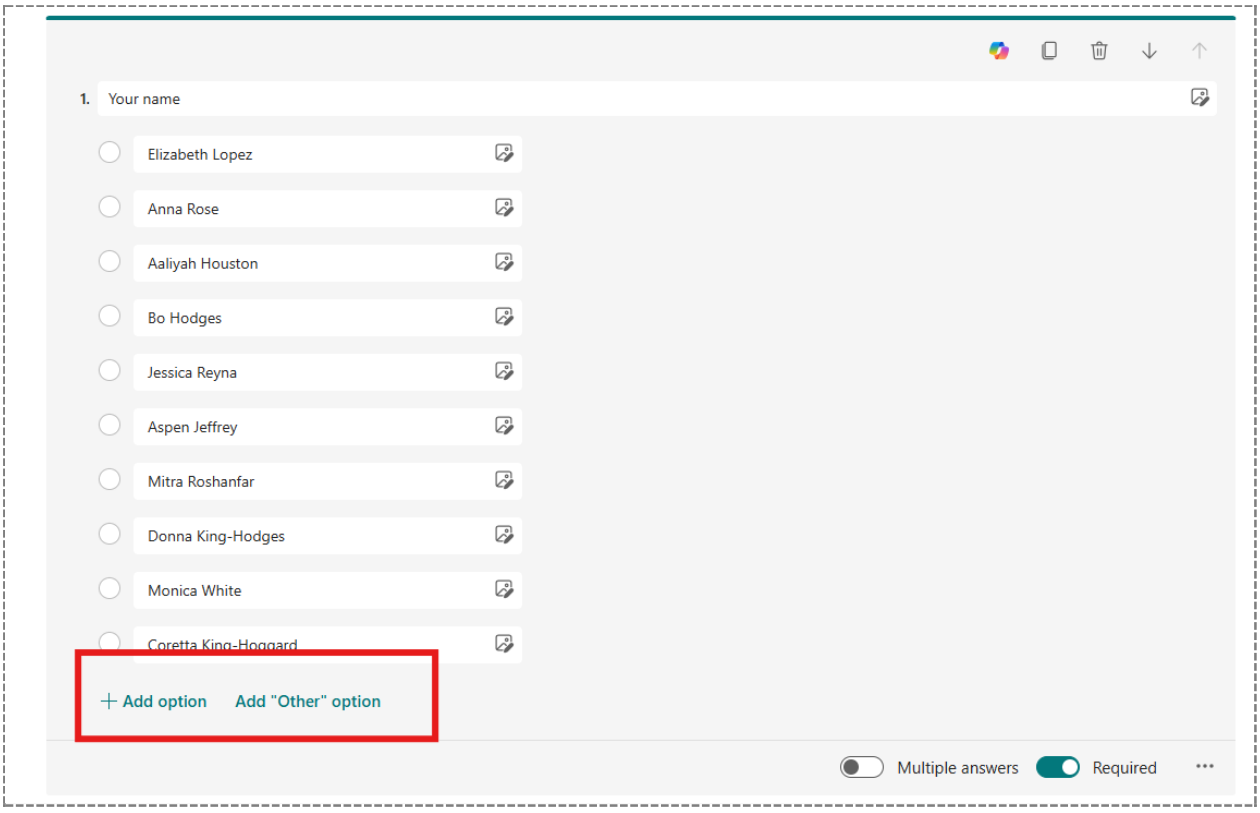


Figure 8. Microsoft Forms – editing the "Your name" choices

6.2 Employee leaves

1. **Employees tab:** enter the Termination date and set Status = Inactive. Grants after that date stop automatically.
2. **Form:** remove the name from "Your name".
3. Unused PTO is not paid out. If the employee leaves on good terms, Management may extend the last day so they use their remaining PTO (log it as PTO used). Otherwise, leave the balance as it is.
4. Do not delete the employee row. Their history must stay in the file.

6.3 Other changes

- **Moves to part-time:** change Employment type to "Part-time (not eligible)". No more grants; the balance stays.
- **Rehire or different PTO start date:** put the date PTO should count from in "Accrual date override".
- **Wrong hire date:** fix the Hire date. If a wrong grant was already logged, add an Adjustment (-) for it; flow 2 adds the correct grant on its date.

7. Fixing mistakes

Golden rule: never edit or delete an approved Log row to change a balance. Add a new row with Adjustment (+) or Adjustment (-) and explain it in Notes (request ID, what was wrong, who approved).

Situation	Fix
Wrong request, not decided yet	Approver rejects it with a comment. Employee submits a new one. Nothing to fix in the file.
Same request sent twice	Approver approves one and rejects the other with "Duplicate". The Log Check column also warns "possible duplicate".
Approved with the wrong number of days	Log: Adjustment (+) or (-) for the difference. Notes: "Correction to MF-xx: requested 3, took 2".
Approved time off cancelled	Log: Adjustment (+) for the days. Notes: "MF-xx cancelled". Requests: Status = Cancelled, explain in Approver comments.
Automatic grant was wrong	Usually a wrong hire date. Fix the hire date, then Adjustment (-) for the wrong grant.
Typo in a manual Log row (name, type, missing data)	The Check column shows it in red. Fix that cell directly; a typo is not a balance change.
Request stuck in Pending	Check flow 1 run history. If the flow failed, set Status = Denied with "Flow error - resubmitted" and ask the employee to resubmit.

8. Troubleshooting

Open Power Automate → the flow → Run history → the failed run → the red action. Read the error and use this table.

Error (red action)	Cause	Fix
Get employee: row not found	The name in the form does not match the Employees tab.	Fix the spelling in the form or the Employees tab. Ask the employee to resubmit. Set the Pending request to Denied.
Id column '…' was not found / GetTable NotFound	A tab or table was added, removed or moved, so the action points to the wrong table.	Open the action and reselect the correct table (for example, Get type → tblTypeMap). Restore the original tab order.
itemNotFound	The file was deleted, renamed or replaced with a new upload.	Restore the file with Version history (section 10), or reselect the file in every Excel action.
File locked for shared use	Someone has the file open or a session is still active.	Close the file everywhere, turn the flow off, wait about 10 minutes, turn it on and resubmit.
TooManyRequests (429)	Too many calls to Excel in a short time.	Wait a few minutes and resubmit. Avoid opening many Excel actions in the editor at once.
Unable to match columns in the filtered view	A column in the table is hidden.	Unhide all columns of the table (make them narrow instead).
#VALUE! or #REF! in the tracker	Rows were inserted or deleted inside a table, or a formula was typed over.	Restore the previous version (section 10).

9. Recovering the file

OneDrive keeps every version of the file. Restoring a version keeps the same file ID, so both flows keep working.

1. In OneDrive, click **…** on RAH_PTO_Tracker.xlsx → **Version history**.
2. Pick the last version before the problem → **Restore**.
3. Re-enter anything recorded after that version. Compare the Requests tab with the approvals in Outlook and with flow 1 run history.

> **To replace the file with a new version:** close it everywhere, then overwrite it with the same name through the OneDrive sync folder on your computer, or with Upload → Replace. Never delete the old file first.

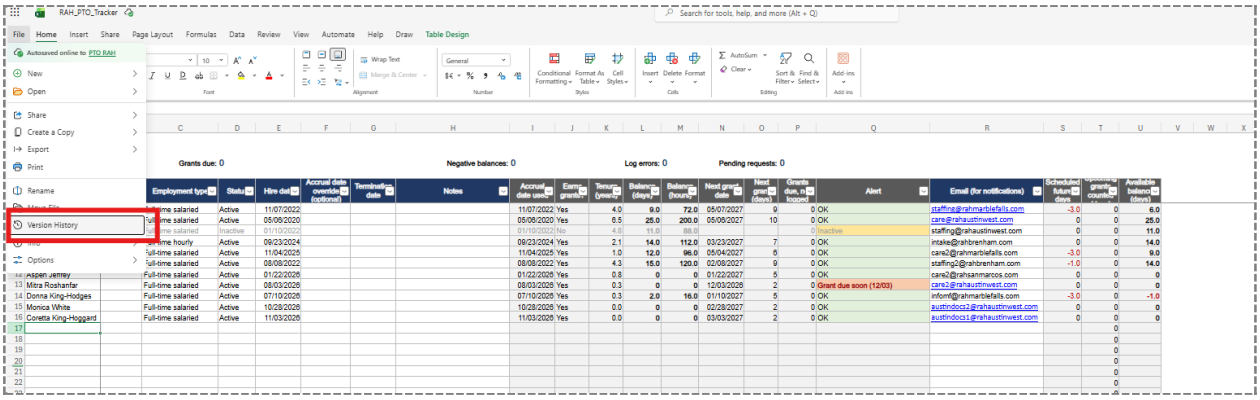


Figure 9. OneDrive – Version history and Restore

10. Testing and changes to the flows

10.1 Testing automatic grants with a future date

1. Settings → **Report date override**: type the test date (for example, 12/04/2026). Check that "Report date used" shows it.
2. Flow 2 → **Test** → **Manually** → Run.
3. Check the new Grant row in the Log, the "Logged" status on the Grant Calendar and the email.
4. Delete the test Grant row from the Log (the only case where a Log row is deleted: a test with a future date).
5. **Clear the Report date override.**

10.2 Common changes

- **Change the Approver:** flow 1 → action "approval" → Assigned to. Also update the "Approver (Power Automate)" line on Settings.
- **Change the grant email recipients:** flow 2 → "Send an email (V2)" → To / CC.
- **Change the 20-day maximum:** flow 2 → "Max balance" (Compose).
- **Change the payroll contact:** flow 1 → "Payroll notice to Allison" → To.
- **Add a request type:** add the option in the form and a row in tblTypeMap (Settings) with the matching Log type. The text must match exactly.
- After any change: **Save**, then run one test.

> **Account dependency:** the flows and the file run under the PTO Administrator's Microsoft account. If that account changes, move the file to a shared SharePoint site and make the Approver a co-owner of both flows before the account is removed.